BUSINESS RATES · ENGLAND · 2026 LIST

Overrated

AI agents that find businesses paying too much in rates, prove it, and fight until the bill comes down.

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THE PROBLEM

Two identical cafés. One pays £3,820 a year more.

CAFÉ A — Rateable value £30,000

£11,460

a year in business rates

CAFÉ B — Rateable value £40,000

£15,280

a year in business rates

+£3,820 a year

Same size. Same street. Same trade. Only the estimate is different.

Illustrative example. Bill = rateable value × 38.2p (2026 rate for shops and cafés under £51,000), before reliefs.

THE PROBLEM

Every bill starts with an estimate.

£35.8bn

in business rates that councils in England expect to collect in 2026–27

1,998,000	properties on the list in England, each one valued by the VOA
£81.6bn	total rateable value: the VOA's estimate of what they would all rent for in a year
+19%	rise in total rateable value on the draft 2026 list, and +22% in London

Sources: gov.uk, NNDR forecast for England 2026–27 (Feb 2026); VOA, draft 2026 rating list statistics.

THE PROBLEM

The fix exists. Almost nobody uses it.

Any ratepayer can ask the VOA to Check, then Challenge, their value. If it comes down, the cut is backdated and the council refunds the difference.

13,710

Checks filed against the 2026 list by 30 June 2026. Fewer than 1 in 100 properties.

58%

of Challenges decided on the 2023 list in England lowered the value

18%

of Challenges were struck out as incomplete

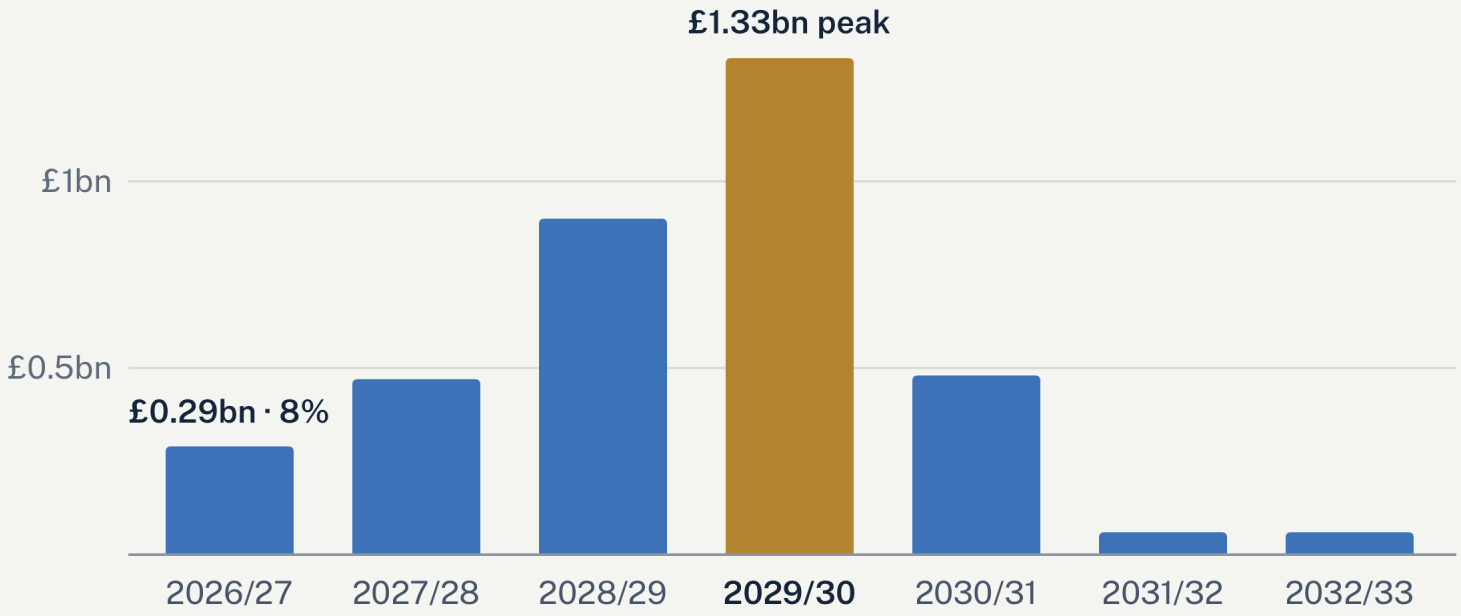
> *For a small shop, the saving often doesn't cover a surveyor's time, so they never try.*

Sources: VOA Check, Challenge and Appeal statistics, 2023 and 2026 lists; Colliers analysis of Challenges to June 2025.

THE PROBLEM

Most of the refunds are still to come.

Expected cuts to rateable value on the 2026 list, by year agreed (£bn)



£1.8bn

in refunds expected from £3.59bn of cuts to rateable values on the 2026 list

8%

of those cuts are expected this year. Three quarters come between 2028 and 2031.

Cases take years to settle. Long-running agents are built for that.

Source: HM Treasury modelling released to Ryan under FOI, reported by Caterer & Licensee, 25 March 2026.

THE PRODUCT

One address. One tap. We do the rest.

01

Type your address

See your street, your price per m^2 next to similar shops, and the likely saving.

02

Tap “Challenge it”

Agents build the evidence pack: similar shops nearby, the maths and the argument.

03

Approve each filing

We file the Check and Challenge with the VOA as your agent, only with your OK.

04

Follow the case

Agents answer the VOA and chase every deadline for up to 18 months.

Free to check · 25% of the saving if we win · Nothing if we don’t

In the demo, filing with the VOA is mocked: its business rates API is still in private trial.

THE PRODUCT · BUILT ON CLAUDE MANAGED AGENTS

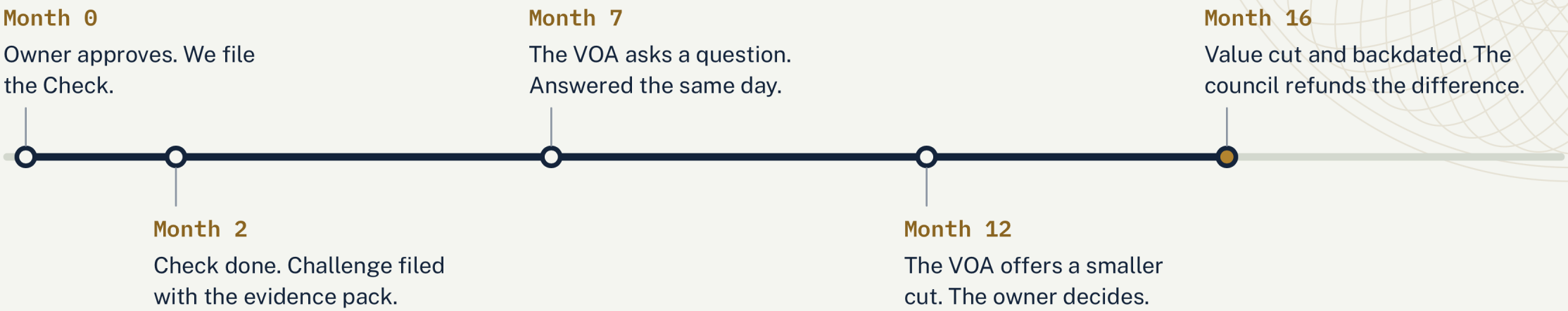
Six agents. None marks its own homework.



Every step lands in a live feed the owner can see, and every session runs on a token budget.

THE PRODUCT

A case can take 18 months. We stay on it.



Between events the Caseworker sleeps. It wakes for a VOA reply, a deadline or its daily check, does the next step, then sleeps again.

Example case for illustration. The VOA has up to 18 months to decide a Challenge, and a cut is backdated.

THE PRODUCT

We test it on cases that already happened.

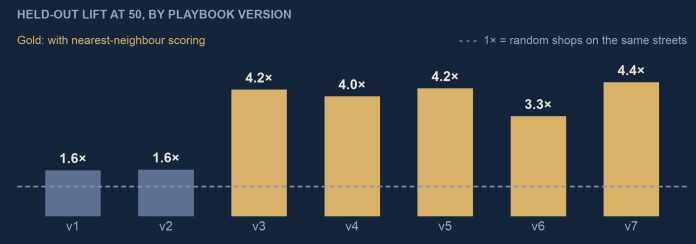
1. Freeze time at April 2023. The agents see only the values as they stood then.
2. The Scout ranks every shop against its street and picks its top 50.
3. Mark the answers: which of those values the VOA later cut, with the floor area unchanged.
4. Compare with 50 random shops from the same streets. The ratio is the lift.

> *A new playbook goes live only if the lift improves on streets it has never seen.*

LIFT AT 50 · HELD-OUT STREETS

4×

as many real cuts in our top 50 as in 50 random shops from the same streets



Data: VOA 2023 and 2026 rating lists and summary valuations, used for rating purposes only.

THE BUSINESS

Others stop at a report, or skip small shops.

	Online checkers	Rating surveyors	Overrated
What you get	A report or an evidence pack	An expert who runs your case	Agents that find, file and fight your case
Who files and follows up	You do, for up to 18 months	They do	Our agents, with your OK on each filing
Price	£29 to £49, one-off	A share of the saving	Free check, then 25% of the saving if we win
Small shops	Served, but you do the work	Often not worth their time	Built for them

Checkers find it. Surveyors fix it, mostly for bigger clients. Our agents fix it for every shop.

Checker prices from checkbusinessrates.uk, Rates X-Ray and businessrates.review, October 2026.

THE BUSINESS

Free to check. Paid when we win.

Free

EVERY OWNER

Check any address and see the likely saving in seconds.

25%

SINGLE SHOPS

of the saving, only if the value comes down. Nothing if it doesn't.

£79

CHAINS

a month per site: every site watched, every change reported to the VOA.

WHAT IT COULD BE WORTH

£10m a year

with 40,000 shops, about 2% of the list

£1m a year with 4,000 shops

Each shop is worth about £250 a year: a £2,000 typical yearly saving, half of cases won, our 25% share.

Ownwell runs this model for US homeowners: 25% of savings, over 1 million appeals, $50m raised in February 2026.

Sizes use the stated assumptions, not forecasts. Ownwell figures from public reports, February 2026.

THE BUSINESS

We reach shops through people they trust.

Business Improvement Districts

BIDs set their levy from rateable value, so they already know every shop on the street.

Accountants and bookkeepers

An app in the Xero and QuickBooks app stores, where small firms already keep their books.

Till and card-payment apps

Listings in the Square and Epos Now app marketplaces reach owners right at the till.

The free check

Every check shows a likely saving in seconds. That number does the selling.

No cold calls and no spam: partners and the free check bring shops to us.

OVERRATED

Overrated finds it, proves it and fights for it.

You only pay if you save.

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